

WAR

The horrific killing of 76 CRPF jawans in a Maoist ambush at Dantewada underlines the failure of soft options. India needs to forge a long-term strategy to eradicate Maoism.

By Sandeep Unnithan and Bhavna Vij-Aurora

"Naxalism is the single biggest internal security challenge India has faced." Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, November 4, 2004.

"All options are reviewed from time to time but we are too close to the event (Dantewada attack) for the existing policy of fighting Naxals to be modified." Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, April 7, 2010.

The Prime Minister, it seems, had peered into a crystal ball to deliver his first dire prediction but six years later, stopped short of announcing a mid-course change. When he first spelt the threat at the annual Directors General of Police (DGPs) conference in Delhi six years ago, critics saw it as a ploy to divert attention from the simmering insurgency in Jammu and Kashmir. The prophetic statement came just two months after a rag-tag group of Naxal outfits met in the dense forests of central India, buried their differences and united under the Communist Party of India (Maoist) and founded the People's Liberation Guerrilla Army (PLGA). They were ill-trained, equipped with crude weaponry and had few resources except a fervent desire for violently overthrowing the Indian state.

Just six years later, the Maoists dealt the single biggest blow in Independent India's long and chequered history of counter-insurgency. Baiting and wiping out nearly an entire company of 76 CRPF personnel who walked into their strongholds of Dantewada. A deadly combination of well-trained cadres, manoeuvring with deadly precision and firepower to destroy Mine Protected Vehicles and massacre well armed security forces, the Maoists signalled a transition from guerrilla warfare to mobile warfare. This was war.

The Dantewada incident once again raised demands for deploying the armed forces against Maoists, something the government is divided on. A meeting of the National Security Council (NSC) was called by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh on the evening of the attack. Attended by Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee, Home Minister P. Chidambaram, National Security Advisor Shiv Shankar Menon and the service chiefs, the NSC considered calling in the army to deal with Maoists. Chidambaram later said the government could revisit the decision of "not using air power", a major shift in the government's stance.

If 26/11 was the wake-up call for the country's anti-terrorism mechanism, the morale-shattering killing of the CRPF personnel was an eye-opener on the government's deficiencies in tackling the Red challenge. Chidambaram, who picked up the gauntlet against the Maoists last year, fought shy of calling it war. "It is the



THE SLAIN CRPF
TROOPS AT
DANTEWADA

VIRENDRA MISHRA